

Portrait Drawing Fundamentals

Master the proportions and structure behind realistic portrait drawing.

The human face is the most studied subject in the history of art, and for good reason. We are wired from birth to read faces. We notice immediately when something is slightly off, even if we cannot articulate exactly what it is. This sensitivity makes portrait drawing uniquely challenging among all subjects. A flower or a landscape can have loose proportions and still look convincing. A face cannot. This guide is built around that challenge, giving you the structural understanding and observational tools you need to draw portraits that actually look like people.

The guide begins with the skull. Before you can draw a face convincingly, you need to understand what is underneath it. The skull determines the widths, the angles, the shadows, and the overall three-dimensional form of a portrait. You do not need to memorize every bone. You do need to understand the major landmarks: the brow ridge, the cheekbones, the jaw structure, the eye sockets, and the chin. Once you can feel the skull beneath the surface, your portraits will immediately gain a new sense of weight and solidity.

Proportions are the next foundation. The classic proportion rules of the head are taught here not as rigid laws but as flexible starting points. You will learn why the eyes sit at the midpoint of the head rather than near the top, why the base of the nose aligns with the bottom of the ear, and why the corners of the mouth typically align with the pupils. More importantly, you will learn how to measure what is in front of you rather than drawing what you think a face looks like. The difference between those two approaches is the difference between a generic face and an actual likeness.

Each feature is covered individually in depth. The eyes, which most students find simultaneously the most exciting and most difficult element of a portrait, get an entire chapter. You will learn the structure of the eye socket, how the eyelid wraps around the spherical eyeball, how to draw the iris and pupil without making them look flat, and how to handle the subtle folds and shadows that give eyes their expressiveness. The same depth is applied to the nose, mouth, and ear.

Light and shadow on the face is the subject of the second half of the guide. The head is a complex three-dimensional form and light reveals that form. You will study how light behaves differently on the planes of the forehead, the nose, the cheekbones, and the chin. You will learn the five elements of light and shadow and how to apply them to a portrait using pencil and charcoal. A series of sphere and head studies walks you through the process step by step.

The guide ends with a full portrait demonstration from the initial gesture through the finished drawing, with twenty annotated images showing every stage of the process. Twenty reference sheets are also included, providing a range of head angles, lighting conditions, and feature studies that you can use for practice. Drawing portraits is a lifelong pursuit. This guide gives you the foundation to pursue it with skill and confidence.